The Emptying — Phase 4 Review and Lock (Colony Sim)

Oct 24, 2026 · @William

The design is complete and reviewed; it builds in Unity 6, starting with a gray-box test of the town-growth AI, and is approved and locked. Status: locked.

Review decisions

Issue	Decision
The first hour	The crown handles what real colonies' governments handled, so the early game is full of decisions: the fort and militia, a common storehouse and granary, surveying and granting land, courts and jail, the church, roads and bridges, the trading post and customs, and the mill. Private building takes over as wealth grows. The goal is to feel like a real colony
Government buildings	The crown has basic, non-upgradable versions of most building types; colonists build the better ones
Kingdom setup	Two choices: founding faith (from a designer-set list; many faiths unlock later or only in play) and starting resources, which depend on race. No kingdom trait
Discovery	Intertwined: a colonist's building (a blacksmith) can unlock a special government building, and the reverse
Population	No hard cap; push as high as performance allows, with depth per person over raw numbers. Up to about 2,000 deeply simulated people is the target, which keeps the game in 3D (confirmed October 26). Icons already exist in William's Unity asset packs. People keep to small circles, the camera decides what's rendered, and off-screen people run as data only

Issue	Decision
Races	Art and animations exist; the work is integration
Old docs	RTS-era Phase 1, 2 and 3 docs marked superseded
The map (design change, October 26)	Random terrain each game, 7 Days to Die-style, replacing the fixed hand-crafted map. Every point of interest (buildings, ruins and so on) is hand-made; where each goes is random. The fixed map had been chosen only for unfamiliarity with random generation

Build order

1. **Gray-box prototype:** no art. Cubes for buildings, capsules for people, zones, a storehouse and 3 production chains. People decide what to build and build it. This proves the core idea first.
2. **First playable version:** humans only, one region, needs and jobs, permissions, crown buildings and zones, self-built homes, about 3 production chains, 3 to 5 discovered laws, influence tiers, one raid type with the alarm.
3. **Layered on after, roughly in order:** beliefs and campaigns; religion (3 faiths, then 7); private businesses and corruption; fragments and settlements; off-map kingdoms and missions; escalation stages; captives and slavery; playable non-human races.
4. Art comes in only after systems work.

Engine and tools

Area	Choice
Engine	Unity 6 (LTS), Universal Render Pipeline
Simulation	Plain C# core separate from visuals, on its own clock
Performance	Jobs and Burst for hot spots; full DOTS only if profiling demands it
Crowds	GPU instancing and level-of-detail

Area	Choice
Data	ScriptableObjects in the editor plus a spreadsheet-to-JSON importer for bulk content and mods
Saves	Compressed binary with permanent IDs
Version control	Git with Git LFS on GitHub
Testing	Unity Test Framework edit-mode tests for the simulation core

- **Licensing:** Unity Personal is free under $200K USD of revenue and funding in the last 12 months; above that, Unity Pro is required, as are console builds.

Lock

- [x] ~~William approved on October 24, 2026: the design is **locked** as the blueprint, and Unity 6 with the tools above is set.~~